

Podium drought ends, but progress remains uneven

India's late surge in Chennai **earned bronze** at the Men's Junior World Cup, while the women's team fell short in Chile.

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India clinched the bronze medal at the FIH Men's Hockey Junior World Cup in Chennai, ending a nine-year wait for a podium finish, with a dramatic come-from-behind victory over Argentina after a late surge in the final quarter at the Mayor Radhakrishnan Hockey Stadium.

While the medal is a welcome result, the most intriguing outcome of any age-group global event such as this is the emergence of future stars. For India, however, it was a disappointing campaign despite dominant wins over weaker opponents in the pool stage. Coach P. R. Sreejesh's (**left**) squad struggled significantly in the crucial knockout matches. The biggest concern was arguably the midfield — historically India's strong suit — that lacked a standout central driving force.

From an Indian perspective, the

